

rise to the Genuine Dharma for the sake of bringing peace and tranquility to the land] in India, *Risshō-ankoku* in Ceylon, *Risshō-ankoku* in Burma, *Risshō-ankoku* in Great Asia, and ultimately *Risshō-ankoku* in the entire *Jambudvīpa*. I shall realize *Risshō-ankoku* from the depths of deepest darkness caused by the five impurities that shroud the 10,000 years of the Era of Final Dharma. It is precisely the prophecy of Buddha Śākyamuni in the Lotus Sūtra and the true reason for our founding master Nichiren Daishōnin's appearance in the Era of Final Dharma. Though I am an unworthy disciple, my faith in Buddha's Golden Words is profound and runs deep, and my faith in this vow likewise is immeasurable.

August 25, though of different month, is the monthly return of the date of the passing of my benevolent mother, Maha Bhiksuni Gyōain Nisso. August 26 in the lunar calendar is July 6, the same number as the day on which I was born, though of a different month. On the night of the monthly return date of my mother's passing and on the morning of the date of my birth in the lunar and solar calendars, a watershed event occurred, an omen wondrous and auspicious was bestowed on me for the Dharma work of *Saiten-kaikyō*, for the Dharma work of bringing the world under one sky, surrounded by four oceans to find refuge in the wondrous Dharma, for the Dharma work of uniting the *Jambudvīpa*. Is it a manifestation of my mother's compassion? Is it some grace enabling me to pay a small portion of filial piety? Despite the insults and slanders of the ignorant, even from Japanese beginning with those at the consulate, and in the midst of this mendicant life of dire poverty, I have obtained merits as prodigious as Sumeru⁷⁰ through my practice of spreading [the Odaimoku].

Immersed in bliss, gratified, hopeful in this vision and conviction, a pure breeze wafting out of the Land of Eternal Tranquil Light⁷¹ rises from beneath my feet, which are firmly planted on the ground. What joy! What joy!

desire of ordinary humans seeking the Buddha realm, and the latter originates in the vow of the Origin Buddha of universal emancipation [At all times making this my thought: "How shall I cause all the living/To enter the Supreme Path/And speedily attain the Buddha-body?"]. It is a realm of "Tranquil is this realm of mine/ever filled with celestial being" brought about by ordinary beings awakening to this vow and who practice the chanting of the Odaimoku.

70 須弥山. A towering mountain at the center of the universe according to Buddhist cosmology.

71 *Jōjakkōdo* 常寂光土. The Land of Eternal Tranquil Light is the realm of the Dharma-body Buddha, the highest of the Pure Lands.

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EXCERPT FROM THE WARDHA DIARY¹

Sevagram Ashram, Wardha, India

October 4, 1933

SEVERAL WOMEN INCLUDING MRS. GANDHI came out to greet us when we arrived at the ashram. The Venerable's² room was on the second floor. We were led upstairs.

In the front of the room, a partially-clad Gandhiji was spinning yarn. A number of disciples and Bajaji sat on either side of him. Facing them sat journalists and others who had requested to see Gandhiji. We were ushered in front of the visitors, almost directly across from Venerable. We bowed in salutation, chanted Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō thrice with palms pressed together. Rev. Okitsu³ introduced me to Venerable, and I presented him with gifts of a tin of *arare* [rice crackers] and a fan. The rice

1 There are several different versions of the Wardha Diary in Japanese, edited by various disciples with easier kanji characters and expressions to assist with reading. This rendition is based on the December 16, 1993 reprint 薬田日記 1, 2, 薬田消息, which is a compilation of the *Wardha Diary I* [entry from October 2, 1933 to October 9, 1933, first published on April 11, 1934] and *Wardha Diary II* [October 10, 1933 to December 13, 1933, first published on August 11, 1934] as well as *Letters From Wardha*, correspondence between Gurujī and his disciple, Rev. Maruyama Gyōryō 丸山行遼上人 [November 13, 1937 to January 24, 1938, first published August 16, 1938].

2 The Japanese term used here is *ou* 翁, a venerable male elder. Gurujī uses this term throughout the journal entry when referring to Mahatma Gandhi.

3 興津忠男師. Reverend Okitsu Tadao left Japan on January, 8, 1932, exactly a month after his ordination, to join Gurujī in India. He stopped in Shanghai en route to India and, upon arrival Feb. 22, became the bearer of the sad news of the Shanghai incident to Gurujī who was practicing alone out of a shed next to a crematory in Bombay. According to the Shanghai Mainichi Newspaper article cited in the 2nd issue of *Geppō* 月報 [Nipponzan Myōhōji's monthly bulletin, a predecessor to *Tenku*], in February 1932, five members of Nipponzan Myōhōji's clergy and laity were attacked by a mob of several hundred during their practice at dusk on the streets of Shanghai on January 18. Rev. Tenzaki Keishō [21] 天崎啓昇上人, Rev. Mizukami Hideo [32] 水上秀雄上人, and Gotō Yoshihira [43] 後藤芳平 were critically injured. Rev. Tenzaki later recovered, joined Gurujī in India and practiced at the Wardha ashram with Gandhi, who called him "Keishō-bai." He was one of three disciples sent by the Most Ven. Kawai Nisshin 河合日辰親下 [22nd Chief Abbot of Nichiren School and 54th Chief Abbot of Myōkenji Temple] to practice with Gurujī in India.

crackers had been offered to me the other day from Mr. Sasakura, who lives in Bombay, and the fan was a gift sent by a devotee in Kōbe.

Venerable looked more youthful than the time I saw him at Bombay's Victoria Pier upon his return from the London Roundtable Conference. His face, so carefree and expressive, seemed ready to break into a smile at any moment conveying innocence much like a child. My greatest concern for Venerable is his health. His longevity is invaluable not only for the Indian people, but to us as well. Today's meeting makes me joyous, like I am holding a priceless treasure.

Tears welled up and rolled down my palms pressed together in veneration, moved by the thought that this very person, so easily breaking into innocent laughter while spinning yarn, is the same one who carries the pain and suffering of 370 million Indians on his shoulders, who offered himself up for the invaluable sacrifice of incarceration and upon whom was imposed a life of punishment in his latter years. Moments like these always move me to tears. What is it about this humble labor of spinning cotton that he finds so enjoyable? Would it be possible to find such profound joy in the rewards of this labor without having noble and selfless aspirations and a father's tenderness toward his destitute kin, seeking to clothe the naked and cover their humiliation? The charkhā to Gandhiji is not a thing that spins yarn, but a close friend ceaselessly spinning out his boundless compassion and copious tears.

The picture of the charkhā in the first book I read on Gandhiji did not stir any interest in me. But as I read more about him, I grew increasingly intrigued by the charkhā. Today when I looked beyond its physical form, I felt an exalted light coming from the charkhā. Unwavering faith perhaps exists as light, which makes one oblivious to its physical form.

Venerable was delighted with my gifts, and in his delight he addressed us. "All things Japanese are beautiful and inexpensive. Still, they are fairly expensive. Is Japan intending to conquer India with them?"

Rev. Okitsu had my written greetings in front of him. There was no time for him to translate it. He had to improvise on the spot. "By which path?" he asked in return.

"By its products," said Venerable, coming right to the point.

India's abundant natural resources have been exploited relentlessly by Great Britain, reducing it to its miserable depths of today. No matter how high the cost of inconvenience, Venerable, who grieves India's state of destitution, cannot tolerate any more of its wealth escaping the country.

"We are bhikshus and are totally unfamiliar with business," replied Rev. Okitsu, deftly dodging the question. He then explained himself by saying, "The biscuits are not a sample product but a token of our hearts."

Venerable appeared convinced that the two beautiful Japanese gifts were not secret envoys coming to conquer India. Maybe not all Japanese are merchants?

"I see. Is this edible, too?" Gandhiji removed the beautiful *noshi* [a strip of red and white paper wrapped around a gift to signify a happy occasion] from the rice crackers box.

"No, that is only for decoration. It's not to be eaten."

"Is this part of the biscuits?" He held up a modest russet-colored cotton cloth with an arabesque design used to wrap the box. Gandhiji looked doubtful about the biscuits' elaborate presentation.

"No, it is cotton simply used for wrapping, and it is not edible," responded Rev. Okitsu, who then switched the subject and introduced me.

After hearing that I have been in the Western Heavens for three years, Venerable asked if I could speak English. Graciously he sought a way to communicate directly, even if it were a word or two. Rev. Okitsu explained that I disliked speaking English.

"You don't like speaking English? That's fine. What about Sanskrit or Pali?" Venerable asked again. Rev. Okitsu candidly confessed that I knew neither.

"Most Japanese Buddhist monks who come to India ordinarily study Sanskrit or Pali." Venerable was perplexed by our audacious ignorance of the languages.

Rev. Okitsu explained the lack of linguistic knowledge by saying, "My master studied Buddha Dharma entirely in Japanese. The study of Sanskrit and Pali can be left up to the scholars. We must devote ourselves to religious work."

"What about Hindi?" Venerable continued.

"He spoke Hindi when he was first in India. But during his year and a half or so stay in Ceylon, he completely lost his Hindi," replied Rev. Okitsu.

"Study Hindi. We shall talk in Hindi." Venerable kindly encouraged me to learn Hindi.

"What have you there? Where do you beat it?" Venerable noticed the drum and opened up a new subject.

"This is a symbol of the Buddha Dharma of Japan. We beat it

wherever we are, whenever we can,” was Rev. Okitsu’s response.

“I see. I have also heard rumors that Japanese Buddhist monks are walking throughout Bombay every night beating the drum.” Venerable indicated that he was familiar with our practice. He then advanced the discussion, “Which school beats the drum?”

“It is called Nichiren School founded by Nichiren Daishōnin in Japan 700 years ago.”

“Does everyone at Nichiren School beat the drum?”

“No, some in the Nichiren School are business oriented, and these people do not earnestly beat the drum. Our master has taught us to beat the drum with all our hearts and chant Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō. We have grown into a Sangha with many disciples and devotees.”

It was already past 4:20 p.m. Venerable smiled and informed us that we had exceeded the time allotted and that today’s meeting must come to an end. All this time, I had my palms pressed together in veneration and eyes closed in gratitude for this extremely rare opportunity. I did not expect to gain anything from the dialogue, but only wished to capture who Gandhiji really is. I was not trying to seek out his opinion nor gain his understanding on any subject. The Indian newspapers all reported that I was chanting the Odaimoku and praying during today’s entire 20-minute meeting. Truly, truly, the 20 minutes slipped by while tears ran down my face.

With affection and seeming reluctance to part, Gandhiji said, “Because of the large number of visitors who come to see me, these meetings naturally have to be time limited. An exception cannot be made for one person.”

“My master also has much more he would like to share with you.” Rev. Okitsu likewise expressed our abiding sentiments.

Venerable slowly turned the charkhā, and his laughter seemed to roll with it as he started to speak again. “Until recently I led a life of a prisoner with no free time of my own. The warden controls a prisoner’s time. It is like I am still in jail here. Bajaji is my warden, and I am back to being a prisoner. Bajaji decides everything, whether I see someone, when I go to sleep or wake up. If Bajaji tells me I can meet with someone for fifteen minutes, I meet him for fifteen minutes. If he says I have 30 minutes, I meet for 30 minutes. If he says I can meet someone for an hour, I meet with that person for an hour. So, you should talk with Bajaji. Bajaji should kindly make convenient arrangements for our next meeting.” Venerable

opened the opportunity for our next meeting.

“My master is unable to speak freely with you.” Rev. Okitsu appeared to be more concerned about my inability to speak the language than the time restriction.

“Write down what you would like to say. Writing should be easier for you than speaking.” He was opening all gates so as to accept our hearts. It was well past the time allotted, and both sides were extending it without end. I felt it was time to bid farewell. We bowed in profound reverence and chanted the Odaimoku thrice. Venerable also took his hands off the charkhā and pressed his palms together in front of his mouth. His penetrating eyes, gazing intently at us over the rims of his spectacles, gradually moistened. I was a visitor from a distant land who could not utter a single word. It was a meeting of merely 20 minutes. I was joyous and sad at the same time. Tears were all that welled up in me. Were we bound to meet by our karmic connection from previous lives or were we newfound friends in this lifetime?

Once we returned to the bungalow, reporters were waiting to hear our story. Rev. Okitsu started with the Japanese biscuits story. I listened by his side. I advised him that the question should have been answered, “If the word ‘conquer’ is to be used, we feel we must conquer India with Buddhism from Japan. It was India that conquered Japan 1,300 years ago with Buddhism, from which all civilization in Japan developed. To return the blessings that Buddhism brought us, it is our duty today to bring Buddhism back to India from Japan.”

“Indeed,” said Rev. Okitsu, and translated this for the reporters. They were amused and wrote it down.

If Gandhiji had asked whether Japan was trying to conquer India with Buddha Dharma, the answer would have been an immediate “yes.” However, since Japan never came to India for spiritual purposes, no wonder Venerable assumed, as Japanese, that we might be representing some business interest, though we stood before him as Buddha’s disciples. To entertain an unfair conjecture, he could have imagined that we were espionage agents for those who would exploit India. Buddhism, which has been handed down over thousands of years, still thrives in Japan, even though it stands at the height of a civilization based on materialism. Not only that, I believe the entire world under one sky will eventually be led to find refuge in the single phrase of the ineffable Dharma.⁴ The

4 Here Gurujī is reiterating the purpose of his mission. 一天四海皆歸妙法. [*itten-shikai-kai-kyōhō*] comes from the writings of Nichiren Daishōnin. “One heaven, four seas,

bold proposal to return Buddhism to the land of its origin must be like a bolt out of the blue, an unlikely proposition that would not readily come to mind. The current mandate driving Japanese civilization is to sell cotton textile to India. The Japanese delegation now attending the Simla Conference,⁵ with self-styled heroic resolve, would rather die than return home without successfully promoting Japanese cotton goods. The Japan-India Association⁶ and the Japanese General Consulate are also concentrating their efforts toward a worthy outcome for the conference in Simla. Is this what they should be doing? If one listens calmly to what is being said, it is even more embarrassing than the British. Japan possesses one thing that ought to be exported abroad. It requires no freight nor is it subject to tariff. Not a single penny would be exploited from the buyer. It is the time-tested crystal of Japanese civilization, a wondrous elixir that regenerates a fallen nation, the principle to unite the East, a bomb that could conquer the world. Japan was not founded for the purpose of promoting cotton textile sales. Why not take a day off from materialism and have a second look at India? As its name implies, the India under discussion in Simla is given as much regard as a lifeless village to be taken advantage of. [Here Gurujī is making a play on words because *simla* 死村, as he wrote it in Japanese, refers to a dead or lifeless village.] Its very name is inauspicious in the first place.

Dusk approached the highlands. A nearly full moon rose atop the full-grown cotton in the field across from the bamboo grove. The cotton field is mixed with corn, which is likewise starting to come into ear. The nocturnal view resembles Manchuria somewhat. As we started out to the ashram for the evening service beating the drum, we were offered a ride since time was drawing near. The service takes place in the courtyard of

everything seeks refuge in the ineffable Dharma." This idea originates in the charge by Buddha Śākyamuni in Chapter XXIII of the Lotus Sūtra to Bodhisattva Medicine King: "I commit to you, in the last 500 years after my extinction, proclaim and spread it abroad in *Jambudvīpa*, lest it be lost." [囑累於汝 我滅度後 後五百歲中 廣宣流布 於閻浮提 無令斷絕] Nichiren Daishōnin awakened to the mission to bring salvation to the Era of Final Dharma with the ineffable Dharma and started chanting Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō. In *Admonishing Bodhisattva Kanyō* [諫曉八幡抄 *Kanyō-hachiman-shō*], he prophesized that Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō would spread widely to China, India and throughout the world. Gurujī found his calling in bringing Nichiren Daishōnin's prophesy to fruition.

5 Simla is an Indian city in the state of Himachal Pradesh, located in the northwest Himalayas. In 1864 it was declared the summer capital of the erstwhile British Raj in India. It was the venue of a conference between the British Empire, India and Japan to resolve the trade war that had broken out between them regarding the import of cotton.

6 Founded in 1903 to promote broad exchange and friendship between Japan and India.

the ashram quarters. The courtyard was full of people, men in the front and women behind them. In the middle was a stool with a cushion for Gandhiji.

A blanket was placed for us to sit near Venerable. We hesitated to accept the special seat and sat behind the blanket so that others might use it. Gandhiji's granddaughter came. I hear she had to be treated for tonsillitis. We inquired about an acquaintance of Rev. Okitsu's whom he had met in Ahmedabad.⁷ We were told anyone who is not here is most likely in jail. The word jail is used most casually here. Perhaps it is understood simply as a place where one can practice what he or she believes. Children crowded around us. They just stood around gazing at us without any distracting clamor. When the bell sounded, a half-clad Gandhiji came, following a lamp that illuminated his way. He walked with an unsteady gait, his arms resting on the shoulders of two attending women. When he took his seat we caught his eye. He placed his palms together in greeting, then whispered to Bajaji, who was attending him, to tell us to move forward onto the blanket.

As someone recited, others followed. The prayer meeting lasted about 30 minutes. As the moon rose higher, moonbeams slanted across the wide highlands, shining cool and clear in the night, the heat of the day all but forgotten. No greeting was exchanged by those who gathered and found their seat on the ground in an orderly fashion. In all, several hundred men and women had assembled. I wondered where they came from. A roll-call of ashram members followed the service. Venerable rose from his seat and returned to his room. After Gandhiji, the women's group stood up and left. Male members then slowly started to leave. They headed towards where we were seated. Perhaps to prevent the crowd from stepping on us, three or four young men joined their hands to shield us. It was also time for us to leave.

We briefly met with Gandhiji's third son. We parted after promising to visit him tomorrow morning. With the moonlight on our backs, we returned to the bungalow, beating the drum. There were still many people behind us. We arrived at the bungalow, passing several groups of women who left before us. Having no appetite, I skipped supper. But people worried and insisted I take milk or fruit. I agreed to have some milk.

7 The largest city in the state of Gujarat, located on the banks of the River Sabarmati.

October 7, 1933

On October 7, 1933, at the satyagraha [grasping the truth] ashram in Wardha, located in the middle of India's central plains, the long-cherished vow of *Saiten-kaikyō* was expounded for Mahatma Gandhiji, the peerless sage of all times and the supreme leader of the Indian freedom movement. Rev. Okitsu translated what I wrote down in Japanese. As it so happened, it was the time of the full moon, and some nights we worked almost till daybreak by the lamp and moonlight. I cannot fathom how hard it must have been for Rev. Okitsu to translate, much harder than my preparation of the text. When Rev. Okitsu finished translating, he said in tears, "Now that I accomplished the greatest work of my life, I don't mind even if I die of fever disease." His immersion in this work was such that he gave all he had. Bajaji's secretary helped Rev. Okitsu with the translation. A young English Literature scholar was asked to read the draft, and he felt the English did not read well and took the liberty of completely rewriting it. Rev. Okitsu thought it over and wondered what good a refined English text would be if our heart did not come through? He suggested we submit the literal translation with its Japanese-flavored English; Venerable would surely see our hearts through the awkwardness of the text. He thus declined the revision. I wrapped the letter in *fukusa* [a small silk wrapping cloth] to present to Gandhiji.

We again left around 4 p.m. today, as it started to cool down once the sun sank low in the sky. When we arrived at the ashram, a disciple of Venerable came out to stop our drumming and explained that "Bapuji" was being examined by a doctor in a room downstairs. We were taken first to the sitting room upstairs.

We did not have to wait long before the half-clad Venerable entered and took his seat with ease while pressing his palms together and bowing back to us. His whole face was a smile. I read in a sūtra⁸ that a holy arhat never fails to greet others with a smile. An unreserved smile cannot come naturally when facing a stranger if the heart is clouded. Although I have always been mindful of this, it is a revered state of mind that does not come easily. As agreed, Rev. Okitsu extended our greetings by saying, "We are deeply grateful to have seen you the other day. My master has written

8 増一阿含經. Increased by One Discourses of the Āgama Sūtras [Sk. Ekottara Āgama] is one of the four of the Āgamas [阿含 āgona], which are collections of early Buddhist scriptures. Translated by 瞿曇僧伽提婆 Gautama-samghadeva in 397.

a letter since he is unable to freely converse with you. You might find it difficult to read because of the poor English. Your response would be greatly appreciated."

I handed the letter to Rev. Okitsu, who passed it to Gandhiji. "You translated it?" Gandhiji asked.

Rev. Okitsu embarrassed, responded, "It's awkward English." The single-minded desire to somehow convey our hearts must have given him the courage to present Venerable with a letter in such crude English.

"Good, good, excellent!" Venerable respectfully accepted it with a smile. "This is a long letter. I will be on my weekly day of silence starting tonight until tomorrow night, and I will not be able to talk with you. My response might have to wait two or three days. Would that be alright? When are you leaving?"

"Two or three days are not a problem. Master is thoroughly enjoying his stay."

"Well, then make yourselves at home. Have you been able to eat Indian food?"

"Yes, it's delicious." Bajaji, who was sitting by, gave a frank report as host that the master had skipped several meals.

"Are you feeling alright? Is anything wrong?"

"No, there is nothing wrong with my master. He was a little tired. Perhaps his mind is over stimulated. He is taking milk and fruit."

"Good, all I take is milk and fruit, too. Let Bajaji know if there is any food you'd like to have." Venerable noticed Rev. Okitsu's cotton drum bag. "I see your bag is torn."

"A mouse chewed it." Rev. Okitsu's response in Hindi brought everyone in the room to laughter.

"Your belongings are falling out from the hole. Can I offer you a bag?" A member of the ashram thought maybe it needed to be made of Japanese cotton.

Rev. Okitsu said, "No, I prefer handmade Indian cotton."

Today's meeting was set for five minutes. It was time to excuse ourselves. Venerable also carries this type of bag during his pilgrimages on foot. The same is true of his disciples. A white cotton bag is worn across the right shoulder and hangs under the left arm. The cloth on the flap extends slightly to be tied with a string. Likewise, cotton is used in briefcases, handbags and such, rather than leather. I shall send one to the people in Japan.

October 8, 1933

We will be seeing Gandhiji at the ashram at 4 p.m. for his response. It was only at 4 p.m. yesterday that we presented him with my letter. It must have been quite a task amidst his busy schedule to read through the lengthy letter. It also must have been the clumsiest English letter out of the countless letters Gandhiji receives. I assume the difficulty for the reader was compounded by its unusual length. When the letter was presented yesterday and Rev. Okitsu mentioned that the translation was inadequate, Venerable flipped the pages and asked if he translated it. Rev. Okitsu said "yes," but later confided to me that a cold sweat suddenly ran down his spine.

Gandhiji looked very pleased and commended the troubles of translating it by saying, "Did you? Well done!"

After the evening service on the 5th, Gandhiji, who was about to stand from his seat, whispered into Bajaji's ear, "What are the Japanese monks doing with their time?" To which Bajaji replied, "They are writing a letter to you." "Oh," said Venerable, and saluted us, who were sitting right next to him, with palms together and left his seat. More than just wondering what we might have to say, I suspect he felt like he was waiting with all ears for the first song of a bush warbler.

An unexpected friend came from a land far away, led by a longing that grew over the years. But he could only convey the trueness of his heart through an unfamiliar tongue. The luster of a gem is not lost even when wrapped in rags. I believe what shines in a person's heart is the mirrored reflection of the heart of another. Venerable was on his weekly practice of silence where he spends time in meditation and contemplation. His response was a thankful surprise since I did not expect it for the next two or three days. For everything, I am so grateful.

A school stands en route to the ashram on the road cars take. Many congregated in the vicinity of the school today. I have no idea where they came from, but many ox-drawn carts were hitched in the shade of the trees. Just like "the ants' pilgrimage to the Kumano shrines,"⁹ an endless stream of local people converged. They came to listen to Gandhiji speak at 6 p.m. We got out of the automobile and, as usual, entered the ashram gate beating the drum. We were led to the room upstairs and were told that the

9 蟻の熊野詣. A metaphor describing the numerous pilgrims who travel along the Kumano Kodo pilgrimage routes to pay homage at the Kumano shrine complex in the Kii mountain in central Japan.

doctor was examining Gandhiji downstairs. By now we are acquainted with many of Venerable's multitude of disciples present in the room. Before long, Venerable entered and returned our greeting with palms pressed together as he took his seat. Venerable said, "I have written my response. Let me read it to you first." He read it out loud and made changes along the way. He gave a copy to his secretary, who incorporated the changes. Venerable wrote down my name on the envelope confirming each letter in the spelling of my name. Through Rev. Okitsu, I first thanked him for his response and then asked if we might make the letter public. "Yes, of course you may make it public."

"When will you be leaving?" asked Venerable.

Rev. Okitsu replied, "We will stay another two or three days since my master is very happy here."

"Then come again tomorrow. Every day at 4 p.m., I have come to really look forward to hearing the valiant sound of your drum. I, too, am fond of the sound of the drum."

The reverberation of Nipponzan's *gyakku-senryō*¹⁰ [drumming and proclamation of the Dharma, Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō] found a kindred spirit in the greatest sage of modern times, the chief commander of India's freedom movement, a representative of the people descended from the lineage of Buddha Śākyamuni, and the one whose joyful acceptance resonated with the sound of the drum. At long last! The long-cherished vow of *Saiten-kaikyō* found the one person with the capacity to receive it in accordance with the time.¹¹ The sweet joyous utterance that escaped Gandhiji's lips at this ashram in Wardha was the joyful voice of 300 million people responding to the Dharma sound of our drum. The wondrous practice of *gyakku-senryō* did not find a kindred spirit among the countless monks in Buddhist Ceylon. The more earnestly I offered it, the greater I was held in contempt. Some, like the Japanese

10 Please refer to *Wondrous First Connection with Lord Buddha's Relic*, footnote 27, p. 14.

11 教機時国鈔. *Treatise on Teaching, Capacity, Time and Country*. Written by Nichiren Daishōnin on February 10, 1262 during exile in Izu, it teaches the five aspects involved in disseminating Buddha Dharma: the teaching [Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō] to be spread; the people's capacity; the time; the country; and the sequence of propagation. Gurujī's statement refers to the teaching [Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō] in this writing as well as a prophecy made by Nichiren Daishōnin in *Admonishing Bodhisattva Hachiman* 諫曉八幡抄. Nichiren Daishōnin predicted "an auspicious omen of Buddha Dharma of Japan returning to India, the country of the moon," and Gurujī believed both teachings were fulfilled on October 8, 1933 [time] through Gandhiji [who had the capacity to receive the teaching] in India [the country].

Consulate General in India, regard Nipponzan as an objectionable presence internationally, and have taken every possible measure, even at times illegal, to oppress us. The average Indian on the street, if not ridiculing us, has been totally indifferent. I have thus ascertained first-hand that no one possesses the kindred spirit capable of receiving this Dharma proclaimed with the drum other than the leader of India's freedom movement. The prayer for *Risshō-ankoku* is not a sound that can be heard by those resigned to slavery in a fallen country nor by the non-virtuous and arrogant who have profited through treachery by selling out their country in order to revel in extravagance. When they hear the drum, they grow frantic and tormented and cannot help but slander the Dharma.

It is not surprising that the true character of our *gyakku-senryō* would not be understood by diplomats pursuing fame and fortune or by Buddhist scholars who lack the sincere heart needed to comprehend the spirit of Buddhist teachings and so intellectualize them and end up writing intently about superficial issues of translation for third-rate magazines. If this were the kind of Dharma readily comprehended by such people, it would soon be trampled underfoot by the British police. How could the reverberation of this great prayer for *Risshō-ankoku* not create a response in the one truly seeking independence for India, oblivious of the cost to life and limb? For one who grieves the people's anguish, who laments the decline of the motherland, is it possible not to believe in and receive this prayer for *Risshō-ankoku* with an open heart?

When I heard Venerable's delight, that he "looks forward to hearing the sound of our Dharma drum" of *gyakku-senryō*, I, who have not found one kindred spirit in this three-thousand great thousandfold world,¹² knew in my heart that "this is the very one, this is the very person."¹³

12 *Sanzen-daisen-sekai* 三千大千世界. Often used to describe the whole universe. A thousand worlds make a small one-thousand world [*shōsen-sekai* 小千世界]. A thousand of them make a medium one-thousand world [*chūsen-sekai* 中千世界]; a thousand of them make a great one-thousand world [*daisen-sekai*]. Because of this triple multiplication by a thousand, it is called "three-thousand great thousandfold world."

13 For the mission of *Saiten-kaikyō* to materialize, thus fulfilling Nichiren Daishōnin's prophecy and thereby the prophecy of Buddha Śākyamuni as well, a person [in fact, a Bodhisattva disciple of the Origin Buddha 本化] with the capacity to receive the Odaimoku was indispensable. Guruji understood Gandhi to be this person. Seen in the light of Chapter II, *Expedients*, of the Lotus Sūtra, "Only a buddha together with a buddha can fathom the Reality of All Existence." 唯仏と仏 乃能究尽 諸法実相. Therefore, this person would be one who would share in the mission to bring emancipation to the Era of Final Dharma. The spiritual relationship between Guruji and Gandhiji can be understood in the context of Chapter II.

Who other than this person, the rightful one, could I possibly expound this teaching of India's *Risshō-ankoku* [the teaching to bring peace and tranquility to India through the Genuine Dharma]. The prayer for *Risshō-ankoku*, the Dharma sound of *gyakku-senryō* now has undoubtedly been transmitted to the Western Heavens. When Gandhiji beats the Dharma drum of Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō, and when the disciples of Buddha Dharma of Japan reside with his disciples, India's independence shall inevitability come in the near future. At long last! On this day in the Era of Final Dharma in the Western Heavens, the momentous mission shouldered by our master, Nichiren Daishōnin, born in Japan, has been fulfilled. Despite all those who despised or disparaged me, who can deny that I have fulfilled a humble part of the mission in the Western Heavens as "messenger sent back to inform"¹⁴ as described in the *Eternal Duration of the Life of the Tathāgata* in the 6th scroll¹⁵ of the Lotus Sūtra? Years of unswerving faith under adversity had been more than rewarded by Gandhiji's single remark. I have beaten my drum, the Dharma of *gyakku-senryō*, in the vast expanse of the three-thousand great thousandfold world searching for this person. He was, as I expected, that very one. Gandhiji was truly that person. Gandhiji was, as I expected, the Gandhiji I was looking for. Venerable, who perceived even sweet Japanese biscuits, a beautiful fan and cotton goods as bitter foes of India, not to mention his aversion to all Japanese state policy, had today without suspicion immediately believed and embraced as a peerless friend in his life of faith the music of an ancient Japanese instrument which dates back to the age of the gods,¹⁶ the sound of the Dharma drum of Na Mu Myō Hō

14 遣使還告. In *The Eternal Duration of the Life of the Tathāgata* chapter of the Lotus Sūtra, the Tathāgata, the father in the analogy, sends home a messenger to inform his children, who have lost their minds by poison and refuse to take the superb medicine of the father, that their father has passed away. Upon hearing this, the children "finally awaken and come back to their right minds." [心遂醒悟] The messenger sent is a disciple of the Origin Buddha. "To inform" is to bring the message that the Eternal Buddha, as an expedient, manifested Parinirvāna for the sake of emancipating sentient beings. Upon final awakening of sentient beings to this fact, the disciple of the Eternal Buddha administers the superb medicine of Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō for them to take. This is how emancipation in the Era of Final Dharma is described to take place.

15 In scroll form, the Lotus Sūtra is encased and consists of 8 scrolls, 28 chapters and 69,384 kanji characters. 一帙八軸四七品 六万九千三三四 一一文是真佛[法華經一部八卷] *The Eternal Duration of the Life of the Tathāgata* chapter is at the beginning of the 6th scroll.

16 The drum is also the first instrument that resounds before Buddha Śākyamuni starts to deliver the Lotus Sūtra.

Ren Ge Kyō, the prayer for *Risshō-ankoku*. The reverberation of the Dharma drum of Buddha Dharma of Japan was, likewise, the ineffable sound of the celestial drum that fortifies Venerable's ideals and conviction here at Wardha in the Western Heavens. The war drum of India's independence movement was the wondrous sound of a single fan-drum that Gandhiji beat as he burst into peals of laughter. When Venerable rejoices in the true purpose of Nipponzan's *Saiten-kaikyō* and joyously embraces the wondrous practice of Buddha Dharma of Japan's *gyakku-senryō*, and when India, thus, attains independence, perhaps for the first time, the frivolous will begin to discuss the role I played for the sake of my country, Japan, and Buddhism in Japan.

The two of us were drawn into Gandhiji's laughter, and we also burst into laughter and rejoiced. My happiness was such that I wondered if it were a dream. "Are you fond of drums? May I present you with one?" Rev. Okitsu stepped forward and offered Venerable a used, *shaku-sun*-sized, round hand drum¹⁷ that had been offered to me by Mr. Miyamoto¹⁸ when I left Japan on my mission of *Saiten-kaikyō* and had since been exposed to the elements.

Venerable's laughter rang out, and he accepted it. "Are you giving me a drum too? I shall beat it too. Ha, ha."

I lifted my drum, placed it in front of me and began to beat it. As I beat the drum chanting, "Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō, Na Mu Myō Hō Ren Ge Kyō," Venerable, still wearing a smile, started to beat his drum, uncertain as he tried to recall the chant written in my letter.

Rev. Okitsu became even more enthusiastic and said, "I'll teach you." His remark is most favorably described as being to the point, but how short it fell in decorum! I wonder if it were customary in the arrogance of English, so deficient in modest grace, to audaciously address even someone like Venerable with such words? How lacking in deference he must have appeared. I blushed with the thought. Oh no!

"You'll teach me? Good. Ha, ha." Venerable laughed and was enjoying beating the drum. Could Rev. Okitsu not grasp the invaluable

guidance offered in this sage's response, which sought to bring out the best in others through his self-effacing humility? By the time I realized the unseemliness, the moment to intervene had already passed.

An attendant by Venerable's side doubtfully asked, "Tomorrow is your day of silence, and you won't be able to speak. You don't mind these people coming here?"

"I won't be able to speak, but we can sit here and see each other smile. I enjoy the monks coming here beating their drums." This kind of affection, when directed at his 370 million countrymen and women, drew forth the unified response of the Indian people, "Bapuji! Bapuji!" "Father! Father!" an honorary title befitting this sage. In the Lotus Sūtra, Lord Buddha repeatedly states that the Tathāgata is the parent of us sentient beings. This boundless parental affection had been inherited by this person.

"Stay as long as you like. Come here every day beating your drums while you are here." Our visit is now in a category that can be extended without limit. The Dharma sound of *gyakku-senryō* has tied us together with a thread of common joy. Ahh! Profound gratitude overwhelms me for the magnitude and wondrous workings of *gyakku-senryō*, whose merits far exceed my capacity. We decided to return to the bungalow momentarily and then head out to the school for the speech, gathering after 5 p.m. The audience, in an orderly manner, filled the expansive schoolyard, which gave the appearance of a drill field, and then overflowed out into the road. A stage was set up on the veranda above the entrance hall. We were both led to the stage. There was still 20 to 30 minutes left before the program opened. We stood on one side of the podium, faced the audience and wholeheartedly chanted the Odaimoku, beating the drum.

Gandhiji made his appearance after 5:30 p.m. and took his seat. He bowed to us with palms together as he took his seat. "Where is your drum?" he asked Rev. Okitsu. That drum had been placed in Venerable's hands about an hour ago. Bajaji declared the meeting open. Prayers and tributes of admiration were offered in accordance with the program. After 6 p.m., just about when the sun sets, Gandhiji was scheduled to give a speech for as long as 20 minutes. However, his speech was read by a young male disciple. After the speech, some started to head home. We stayed when it was decided the evening prayer would take place here. Lights were on by the time Gandhiji left at the end of evening prayer. We stood up and saw him off, chanting and beating the drum. The audience

17 団扇太鼓. *Uchiwa-daiko* is a round drum with a wooden handle. A *shaku* [尺一寸] is approximately 30.3 cm, and *sun* is 3.03 cm. About 13 inches.

18 Miyamoto Unosuke 宮本卯之助, the 5th generation proprietor of Miyamoto Unosuke Shōten founded in 1861, which makes *taiko* drums as well as other festival instruments and *mikoshi* portable shrines.

gradually thinned out as if untangling twisted thread.

Bajaji prompted us saying, "Let's go home."

As we started to walk down the staircase we ran into Venerable's secretary, Kaka Kalelkar,¹⁹ from whom I had parted uncomfortably after a disagreement we had on the train regarding the precept against taking life. He courteously greeted me and Rev. Okitsu respectively saying, "That was a very fine prayer." Even for those who may not see eye-to-eye when it come to the precept against taking life, the ineffable sound of *gyakku-senryō* brings all together in one joyous state of mind.

Today was the day the Dharma drum was bestowed on Gandhiji. Today was the day the great Dharma drum was beaten on Gandhiji's stage. It was the day the celestial drum in prayer for *Risshō-ankoku*, an offering from Japan, resounded in India's revolutionary movement. All that is needed in *Saiten-kaiyō* from hereon is an extension of this day. Perhaps today can be said to be the precise time of "final awakening"²⁰ for the Indian people. The darkness of the long night that has shrouded India shall start to clear.

19 A close associate of Mahatma Gandhi, a great prose-writer, editor of *Sarvodaya* periodical and freedom fighter, Dattatreya Balakrishna Kalelkar [1885-1981] was lovingly known as Kakasaheb Kalelkar in Gujarat and all over India. Guruji met Kaka [uncle] or Kakasaheb on the train to Wardha when he first visited Gandhiji and ever since cherished a life-long friendship. Among all of Gandhiji's associates, Guruji had the closest association with Kakasaheb. He attended various Dharma works of Nipponzan Myōhōji throughout Japan as a guest, and several members of Nipponzan Myōhōji and Sarvodaya studied under him.

20 心遂醒悟. Lotus Sūtra Chapter XVI, *The Eternal Duration of the Life of the Tathāgata*. Please refer to footnote 14.

LETTER TO GANDHIJI ¹

October 4, 1933

Wardha, India

NA MU MYŌ HŌ REN GE KYŌ

I am a disciple of the Preceptor, Buddha Śākyamuni, born in Imperial Japan.² My name is Fujii Gyōshō.³ Since the introduction of Buddhism some 1,300 years ago and until recent years, my country, Imperial Japan, professed faith in Buddhism from the top on down. While China's Confucianism and Taoism were also introduced, what they taught us did not go beyond aspects of literature, philosophy and ethics in a civilization. As for religion,⁴ it can be said that Japan is a purely Buddhist nation. There is no Japanese civilization⁵ to speak of which was not influenced by Buddhism. Buddhism, which originated in India, is truly the womb for

1 This is an excerpt of the letter Guruji presented to Gandhiji on October 7, 1933.

2 大日本帝国. *Dainippon-teikoku*, officially Empire of Greater Japan, more widely known as Imperial Japan, was a political entity that existed from the promulgation of the Constitution of the Empire of Japan on 1889 until its defeat in WWII in 1945, which spanned over the reigns of Emperors Mutsuhito 睦仁, Yoshihito 嘉仁 and Hirohito 裕仁, now known by their posthumous names corresponding to their eras of Meiji, Taishō and Shōwa.

3 藤井行勝. Gyōshō means "practice is foremost supreme".

4 Here Guruji is defining religion to mean first, *Honzon*, the principle object of veneration; second, the people who are emancipated by the *Honzon*; and third, the teachings expounded by the *Honzon*, which are the methods to bring salvation. Shintoism, which is indigenous to Japan, lacks any formal doctrine regarding salvation, and the noumenon of Honzon is not clearly defined. Furthermore, what is meant by human beings becoming gods is not clear. Warriors or public figures have been posthumously enshrined as deities. Enemies of state power that are destroyed have also been enshrined as gods to appease their grudges and to prevent their spirits from wreaking vengeance. Therefore, from the perspective of Buddhist doctrine, Shintoism does not fulfill the prerequisite of a religion.

5 "Civilization is not about installing electric lights, having airplanes or producing nuclear weapons. What defines civilization in its entirety? It is not to kill; not to destroy; not to wage war. It is about people holding one another in mutual affection and respect. There is nothing else that defines a viable human civilization." From *Deeply Venerate the Triple Jewel*, found in *Tranquil is This Realm of Mine*.